

Cardo and Decumanus: The Roman Street Grid

What those street names mean when your guide keeps saying ‘Cardo IV’

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Somewhere on this trip, a guide said “turn left at Cardo III” and I nodded like I knew what that meant. I didn’t. Here’s what I looked up later.

The Basic Grid

Roman city planners used two types of streets to organize everything:

- **Cardo** — runs north–south. The main one was called the *Cardo Maximus*.
- **Decumanus** — runs east–west. The main one was the *Decumanus Maximus*.

Together they form a grid, and their intersection was typically the center of city life — near the forum, the temples, the baths, the shops.

The modern analogy is almost too simple: cardo = avenues (north–south), decumanus = streets (east–west). Once you have that, any Roman city plan starts to make sense.

Why It Matters When You're Walking Around

In a site like Herculaneum, the excavated city is laid out in blocks (*insulae*) separated by cardines running toward the sea and decumani crossing them. When a guide says “we’re on Cardo IV” or “this is the Decumanus Maximus,” they’re just telling you your coordinates in the Roman grid.

There could be several parallel cardines (the plural is *cardines*) and several decumani — numbered out from the center. The Cardo Maximus and Decumanus Maximus were the main arteries; everything else was smaller and numbered outward.

The Center Was Always the Forum

The intersection of the two main streets almost always put you near:

- The **forum** (marketplace, civic center, political hub)
- Temples
- Public buildings
- Shops and baths

If you’re ever disoriented in a Roman ruin, find the forum and you’ve found the center. Everything else radiates from there.

Quick Reference

Term	Direction	Main Street	Plural
Cardo	North–South	Cardo Maximus	Cardines
Decumanus	East–West	Decumanus Maximus	Decumani

It’s a small thing, but knowing it makes the whole experience land differently. The Romans weren’t just building streets — they were imposing a coordinate system on the landscape, and they did it the same way wherever they went.